National Qualifications 2024

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ESOL
Listening transcript

FRIDAY, 24 MAY

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Instructions to reader(s):

Recording 1

The conversation below should be read clearly and naturally. After reading the introduction you should pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to read the questions. On completion of the first reading pause for 10 seconds, then read the conversation a second time. On completion of the second reading pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to write their answers.

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(t) **Recording 1. Listen to the recording and attempt the questions which follow. You will hear the recording twice. You now have one minute to read the questions in Recording 1 before the recording begins.**

(*1 minute pause*)

TONE

Presenter That was the latest track by Cassie Harper who will be touring the UK this summer — tickets on sale now. Next up — could e-scooters be the future of transport? We have two callers on the line, Fred Clark and Jennie McGregor, who are keen to share their views. Fred, I believe that you have some strong feelings against e-scooters. Tell us more.

Fred Well, yes. It may be surprising, given the number around, and the fact that people seem to believe they can be ridden everywhere, but the fact of the matter is that electric scooters whether bought or rented, cannot legally be taken out on the road in the UK. Despite what you might see, they are not allowed on pavements either. The only place where it's not against the law is on private land, providing you have permission of the owner, of course. So, it's very disappointing that more is not being done to stop people from being able to purchase these awful things. What's the use in spending anywhere between 150 and 1000 pounds on something that you can't use anywhere?

Presenter Hmm . . . Jennie, what are your thoughts?

Jennie I feel that the UK is dragging its heels on this. Private e-scooters are already legal in most of Europe and much of the US. And it's not strictly true that e-scooters cannot be legally used anywhere; trials of e-scooter rental schemes are taking place in cities all over England — very successfully I might add. I'm with Fred on one thing, though, it makes no sense that you can buy one in a shop but you are not allowed to ride it home.

Fred Interesting that you mention the rental trials. Just yesterday I saw on the news that one scheme in Coventry had to be paused after just five days because people were riding in pedestrianised areas. I was absolutely shocked to see news reports showing riders racing down the pavement to avoid waiting in queues of vehicles, narrowly missing pedestrians, and going the wrong way down clearly marked one-way streets — into oncoming traffic! Not only that but there were scooters discarded all over the city centre by people who couldn't be bothered to take them back to the charging points.

Jennie Right, yeah — I saw that report too. But there are always teething problems when it comes to introducing new systems. I'm not naïve — I understand that there is a risk to pedestrians from e-scooters. Of course there need to be laws outlining how they can be safely and lawfully used on our roads. I'm also in favour of making it compulsory for anyone planning to use an e-scooter to purchase insurance and wear appropriate safety gear.

Presenter Thanks, Jennie. Safety does seem to be a key concern of many people. Would you like to comment further on that aspect?

Jennie My opinion is that the most dangerous riders are the 'renters'. This is because they tend to ride less frequently than people who own their own e-scooter; therefore, they're often more irresponsible and less safety conscious. E-scooters, used responsibly, are no more dangerous than bicycles and have broader appeal. Not everyone can ride a bike — individuals with mobility issues, for example. Bikes are often unsuitable for them.

Presenter Some interesting points. And what about the environmental impact?

Jennie Well, yes, exactly. There are no emissions, so they are significantly better for the environment.

Fred True. But I'm not convinced the environmental benefits are as vast as the manufacturers would lead us to believe. They promote the idea that their e-scooters reduce car journeys which may be true in some cities in, for example, the US where there is no alternative to the car. But most UK cities have excellent public transport, and shops and facilities are more local. In truth, people who take trips on e-scooters would be more likely to have been walking as an alternative, not driving private cars.

Presenter Well, I'm afraid that's all we've got time for. Thanks both, for joining me today. You've certainly given us plenty to think about. Next up, the news and weather with . . . (*fade*)

(*10 second pause after first reading*)

TONE

(*1 minute pause after second reading*)

TONE

[Turn over

Instructions to reader(s):

Recording 2

The monologue below should be read clearly and naturally. After reading the introduction you should pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to read the questions. On completion of the first reading pause for 10 seconds, then read the monologue a second time. On completion of the second reading pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to write their answers.

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(t) **Recording 2. Listen to the recording and attempt the questions which follow. You will hear the recording twice. You now have one minute to read the questions in Recording 2 before the recording begins.**

(*1 minute pause*)

TONE

Presenter Hello, I'm Samir Begum. Welcome to my podcast, which is all about the world of work.

Before we transport ourselves to the future, let's return briefly to the past. Have you ever thought about the jobs that were available to your grandparents', or even your parents' generations? At that time, people tended to have just one or two jobs throughout their lives, whereas nowadays, it is normal to change jobs more regularly. The way we work is changing too. Instead of the traditional 9 to 5, more companies are offering their employees a choice of working patterns that provide flexibility. What is more, the variety of occupations has expanded with new jobs and industries emerging. So, what might the future look like in terms of these new jobs in the next decade or so? While some jobs don't even exist yet and can barely be imagined, others can be predicted.

One way of predicting this is to take account of what we already know will almost certainly happen in the next decade. First, let's consider this: with 8 billion people already on the planet at the present time, the future global population is estimated to reach almost 8.5 billion within the next ten years. Here in the UK, we'll be especially affected by an ageing population who will have specific requirements. There could be fewer younger people, meaning a smaller working population and potentially a shortage of workers. So, in the future, we can predict that a larger proportion of workers are likely to be involved in looking after the elderly.

Due to our ageing population, one of the fastest growing sectors will be medicine. Courses training students in a variety of health specialisms have increased significantly in the last decade and that's expected to continue. As the population ages, we'll need more doctors and nurses, as well as administrators who can manage the complex hospital systems. Therapists and lifestyle consultants who focus on mental health and exercise are examples of this growing trend.

Another industry that is expected to continue its upward trajectory in the future is technology. Thinking about current technology and the dynamic situation of the tech industry will give us an indication of future jobs. IT employees will need to provide sophisticated protection as cybersecurity threats grow and, as a result,

skilled workers in the IT security field will be in high demand. Specialists in computer support and software developers are also going to be sought after, while other tech roles could become a thing of the past. Artificial Intelligence, or AI, will likely remove the need for many occupations with repetitive tasks.

A further growing market for employment will be in the field of education. Online learning has already become a major educational tool. Most universities will continue to offer both online and offline degree courses and this new hybrid system will need both designers and teachers to deliver learning that's constantly up to date and more and more individualised. Even conferences and meetings will take place as much online as offline. The number of people returning to college at different stages of their life will grow as they try to update their existing skills and learn new ones. Education will be a necessity and not a luxury only the rich can afford if we are to adapt and thrive in the new economies of the future.

In our next episode, we will examine this issue in more detail when I will be joined by . . . (*fade*)

(*10 second pause after first reading*)

TONE

(*1 minute pause after second reading*)

TONE

[Turn over

Instructions to reader(s):

Recording 3

The conversation below should be read clearly and naturally. After reading the introduction you should pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to read the questions. On completion of the first reading pause for 10 seconds, then read the conversation a second time. On completion of the second reading pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to write their answers.

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(t) **Recording 3. Listen to the recording and attempt the questions which follow. You will hear the recording twice. You now have one minute to read the questions in Recording 3 before the recording begins.**

(*1 minute pause*)

TONE

Presenter Are you considering studying at university but feeling concerned you might have missed your moment? Being a mature student is actually quite a popular choice nowadays but if you're facing a dilemma about whether or not to take the plunge, we have an expert panel here to give you just the push you need. In the studio today are Alan Jones, head of international recruitment at the University of Carlisle, and Claire Cameron, who recently graduated at the age of 36. Good morning, Alan and Claire.

Alan Good morning.

Claire Good morning. Thanks for inviting me.

Presenter So, Alan . . . for our listeners, can you tell me . . . what is a mature student? At what age does a person qualify?

Alan There's no firm definition. However, students over the age of 21 are often referred to as mature students . . . although sometimes universities will also use other terms such as adult learners or adult returners. I'm often asked if there is an upper age limit to apply to study at university or if there's a preference given to younger applicants and I'm happy to confirm that neither of these is the case. All universities will welcome applications from individuals across many different circumstances and life stages. We think that mature students make a valuable contribution to the diversity of the student population.

Presenter And what's the selection process for mature candidates?

Alan There's no requirement for mature applicants to have any recent qualifications before they start a degree. At Carlisle, we ask all of our mature applicants to attend an interview where we ensure that they have sufficient confidence and potential to make progress on their chosen degree course. They often don't have recent experience of studying but can excel with the right support and encouragement. Mature applicants will often have a varied educational and employment background and they can transfer these skills into an academic context. And of course, if anyone finds the application procedure challenging, assistance is available in the form of online information events and individual coaching sessions.

Presenter Thanks, Alan. Now if I could turn to you Claire, well you have just graduated, congratulations and well done!

Claire Thank you.

Presenter In terms of the university experience, do you think that it's different for mature students compared to young people who have just left school?

Claire Well, I think that many aspects of university life are similar for all students, but there are specific considerations such as caring responsibilities and support with study skills which mature students may need to take into account. I found it quite hard at first because I have a young daughter and I wanted to make sure she wasn't negatively affected by my focus on learning. I found that speaking to my tutor really helped me. When she realised what I was struggling with she couldn't have been more helpful.

Alan That's great to hear. In terms of study skills, at the university where I work, we encourage mature students to speak to younger students, those who've perhaps come straight from school, as they will probably be facing similar challenges.

Presenter Claire, do you have any tips on balancing university with family commitments, and well, everyday life as a mature student?

Claire I think you need to be organised and prepared for the expectations of higher education in advance because university life can be quite overwhelming; it can all feel so new and challenging at the start of term. It's important to try and find some routines for the study time needed and to find ways to balance this with other commitments.

Alan Yes, and everyone who is part of a student community will also have access to a range of support services to help them during their time at university. We want all students to have the best possible experience.

Presenter Well, I'm afraid that's all we have time for. (*fade out*) Thank you both for talking to me today.

(*10 second pause after first reading*)

TONE

(*1 minute pause after second reading*)

TONE

(t) **You now have 1 minute to check your answers.**

(*1 minute pause*)

(t) **This is the end of the listening test.**

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